

Which leads me to the question of whether our differences are the result of childhood money messages, adult life choices, life experiences, birth order or simply inherent dispositions? Would we have had the same financial upbringing if we'd grown up in another geographical area or environment? Does my position as eldest child and my feelings of responsibility mean I'm more or less financially responsible, or does it go deeper than that? Did growing up in a working-class neighbourhood affect our financial resilience one way or another, or was where we lived inconsequential?

Of course, not everyone would pin the differences between my sister and me on the interplay between nature and nurture—not everyone believes in the power of the relationship between nature and nurture. There are some who argue solely for genetics and others who argue solely for experience.

If you believed nature was solely responsible, you'd argue the reason my siblings and I are so different is simply because of our genetic predisposition. Philosophers such as Plato and Descartes suggested certain things are innate, that we're born with these traits and they will always occur regardless of any external influences. In other words, nurture has no impact on them. On the other hand, if you believed nurture was solely responsible, you'd argue the reason my siblings and I are so different is because of the sum of our birth order and our individual experiences both within and outside our family home only. Thinkers such as John Locke believed in the individualism of each person—that we are each a 'blank slate' and all of our ideas, thoughts, personality traits and beliefs come about because of our life experiences.

Yet, when I look to the diverse example of my siblings, these extreme positions are difficult to reconcile.

Today, thanks to research findings contained in studies such as the Dunedin Multidisciplinary Health and Development Study (also called the Dunedin Study—more about this in the following chapter), we now recognise that both nature and nurture play a critical role. In fact, researchers in a variety of fields have discovered that understanding how nature and nurture interact can be critical to understanding choices around education, financial health and general decision-making processes as we get older.